supplementing the resources the Company would be prepared to pour into Himalayan intelligence gathering, and increasing the number of operatives Wade could employ, it had also authorised an operation directly into Wade's territory over which he had no control, and which had emerged from Pottinger's competing Bhuj Agency and was run out of the rival Bombay Presidency. Wade quickly came to see Burnes as a major threat to his position, and as the number and quality of Burnes's reports from Kabul began to increase, Wade began annotating them with sarcastic and patronising comments as they passed through Ludhiana, gleefully pointing out any errors he spotted.[73]

Aware that he was now suddenly the desk-bound Afghan expert who had never actually been to Afghanistan, Wade grew still more irritated with his dashing younger rival when Burnes began to come to very different conclusions about British interests in the region to those canvassed by Wade's Agency. Wade had always seen the relationship with Ranjit Singh as the Company's primary alliance in north India, and strongly believed that the Sikhs were by far the most powerful military force in the region. Indeed having spent much time in the Sikh court throughout the 1820s, Wade was close to becoming a partisan to their cause, something his superiors were aware – and indeed wary – of. He was much less interested in Afghanistan, disliked what he had heard of Dost Mohammad and mentally had his Ludhiana friend and neighbour, Shah Shuja, lined up as Britain's potential puppet in Kabul, if the need should arise.

Wade's views had, however, not kept up with the changing reality. Since Shuja's last failed attempt to recapture his throne, Shah Mahmoud had died and Afghanistan had fallen almost completely under the sway of the Barakzai brothers; only in Herat did Shah Mahmoud's son, Prince Kamran, hold out as a last bastion of Sadozai rule. Despite this, Wade continued to look on the Barakzais as Shuja saw them: as ambitious and unprincipled usurpers.

Burnes, coming to it with fresh eyes, saw things differently. On his way through Ludhiana to see the Governor General, in between saying goodbye to Ranjit Singh and setting off for Afghanistan, he had come to pay court to Shah Shuja and had been unimpressed. Despite Shuja telling Burnes that 'had I but my kingdom, how glad I should be to see an Englishman at Kabul, and open the road between Europe and India', Burnes remained unconvinced. 'I do not believe that the Shah possesses sufficient energy to